WRENFORD BOROUGH COUNCIL

Defect Standard: Vegetation

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1. Purpose and scope

This standard sets out what a report of its defect type must show before a Highways Inspector may order a repair straight from the report, and what follows the decision.

It is used by the Street Care Coordinator or Highways Inspector who opens a review, by the Highways Inspector who decides it, and by the residents, businesses, councillors, bus operators and schools who report defects, as the Highways Policy describes.

Each defect type has its own defect standard. The five defect standards share one layout and many of the same sentences; they differ in what the defect type covers, in the requirements of section 4 and how section 5 reads them, and in what an inspection records, the writing that follows a decision and the reasons that sections 6 to 9 give. A report is always reviewed under the standard of its own defect type, and under the standard of its linked defect type where it has one; a requirement in one standard never applies to a report of another defect type unless the report is linked to it.

The standard applies to every report of its defect type, whichever channel it comes through.

2. What this standard covers

This standard covers trees and hedges that overhang the footway or the carriageway of any street the council maintains lower than the clear height that keeps people and vehicles safe.

Branches hanging over a street light may be reported as a vegetation defect with street lighting as its linked defect type, and a hedge over a broken footway as one with footway, or either the other way round; either way the report must meet both standards.

The defect type is Vegetation.

3. Who reports

A report is made by whoever sees the defect - a resident, a business, a councillor, a bus operator or a school - through one of three channels: the council website's report form, the StreetCare app on a phone, or a telephone call that the contact centre types up.

The report gives the street, its district and its street category, where on the street the defect is and whether that location is fixed, the defect type and any linked defect type, and the answers its requirements read. The council adds how many reports the same location has had before and the planned crew hours from its own standard times. The documents attached to a report - a resident description, a call note, a photo note or an inspection note from an earlier visit - describe the defect.

A vegetation report gives whether the vegetation overhangs the footway or the carriageway, the clear height under it and whether the tree or hedge grows on highway land.

4. Requirements

Every requirement below must be Met for a Highways Inspector to order a repair straight from the report. Each requirement is stated once, in one sentence, and a report is screened against all of them, in this order:

1 **Location fixed.** The location of the defect is fixed to a house number, a lamp column number or a road junction.

2 **Highway land.** The tree or hedge grows on highway land.

3 **Clear height.** The clear height under the overhang is less than 2.4 metres over a footway, or less than 5.1 metres over a carriageway.

A requirement is never met by a sentence in a statement, and is never waived.

5. Reading the requirements

Each requirement is Met, Not met or Not documented on the report as the Report Rules read it. The latest revision of a report is the report; an earlier revision is never screened.

- A location is fixed when the report ties the defect to a house number, a lamp column number or a road junction, so that a crew can find it without a search. The requirement is met when the report records the location fixed, not met when it records that it is not, and not documented when the answer is blank.
- Highway land is the land the council maintains as part of the street, verges included; a tree or hedge growing in a private garden is its owner's to cut. The requirement is met when the report records the vegetation on highway land, not met when it records that it is not, and not documented when the answer is blank.
- The clear height is the height from the surface to the lowest branch or leaf over it, in metres to one decimal as the Report Rules convert it from feet, and its figure depends on where the vegetation overhangs. Over a footway it is met when the clear height is less than the footway figure, and over a carriageway when it is less than the carriageway figure; a clear height of exactly the figure does not meet it, because the street is clear at that height. A blank overhang location is not documented and asks for the overhang location alone, and a blank clear height is not documented.

A requirement that is not documented names the answers it needs, so that the inspection can find them.

A report with a linked defect type is screened under this standard and under the linked type's, and must meet both. The documents never decide a requirement. A measurement sentence whose figure differs from the report's own, or gives a figure the report left blank, is flagged for the Highways Inspector, and the report's answer still decides.

6. What an inspection records

When a report is sent for inspection on site, the inspector who visits records what this standard needs to decide the repair: whether the vegetation overhangs the footway or the carriageway, the clear height under it measured with a height pole, whether the tree or hedge grows on highway land or in a private garden, and the location fixed to a house number, a lamp column or a junction.

7. The works order

The works order goes to the council's repair contractor when a Highways Inspector orders a repair under this standard. It names the report by its report reference and defect type, says the repair is ordered, and gives the street, the location, the defect's own measurements and the repair this section names: a cut back that clears the street to the clear height of this standard. A linked defect type is named with its own repair. It asks the contractor to cut back to the clear height and to clear the cuttings from the street. The works order carries no figure from a model.

8. The resident update

The resident update is written after the works order, for the person who reported the defect. It tells them in plain words that a repair has been ordered, what will be done and where. For vegetation it says that the tree or hedge will be cut back to keep the street clear. Where the repair depends on a linked defect, the update says so. The update never gives the repeat likelihood, the expected crew hours or any other figure from a model, never promises when the work will be done, and never names any member of the council's staff.

9. Why these requirements

Low branches strike people walking and the roofs of buses and lorries. The clear heights of section 4 are the heights a person and a high vehicle need, and at exactly that height the street is clear.

A tree or hedge in a private garden is its owner's to cut, so the council orders a cut back only on highway land and writes to the owner after an inspection otherwise.

Highways Asset Management owns this standard, reviews it every twelve months and issues any amendment as a new issue of this document, replacing every earlier issue.